

by innumerable snakes; but he disperses them by singing a myth, in which he describes the origin of their race.

When he joins the banquet, Ahti is received with all the discourtesy that an uninvited guest might expect. He is ordered to sit at the lower end of the table, and neither beer nor provisions are brought for his refreshment. When he remonstrates against this inhospitable treatment, he is regaled with miserable fragments, and with beer of the worst quality, in which, moreover, he discovers snakes and other reptiles. These he fishes out of the can by a regular process of angling, and destroys with his knife; after which he drinks the liquor, and offers to pay hard money for further entertainment. The host of Pohjola (hitherto a much less conspicuous personage than the hostess) answers this proposal by causing a pool of water to appear before the feet of Ahti, who by a counter-spell conjures up a bull, that drains it to the bottom. The host raises a wolf to oppose the bull, and Ahti, on the other hand, evokes a hare to damp the appetite of the wolf; the host sets a dog to hunt the hare, Ahti attempts a diversion with a squirrel, which is attacked by a marten, which is chased by a fox, which is arrested in its progress by a hen, which is confronted with a hawk. Tired of this magical duel, the host at last challenges Ahti to a combat with swords, which is fought outside the banqueting-hall. Ahti strikes off the head of his antagonist, and seeing a row of spikes covered with human skulls, places it on the only one which has been left vacant. To avenge the death of her husband, Louhi, by means of incantations, summons all her people to the spot; but Ahti, who escapes with difficulty, by changing himself into an eagle, returns safe, though in a very sullen mood, to the residence of his mother.

Feeling, however, that he has exposed himself to no small peril by incurring the anger of the northern people, Ahti, by the advice of his mother, leaves his home, and departs in a boat to a secluded spot, taking with him sufficient pork and butter to suffice for two years. As he approaches the place of his destination, he is kindly received by a company of damsels, who tell him that he may hide himself in safety, and are astounded at the power of his song, which causes trees to spring from the ground, and works divers other marvels. Assuring them that he can sing even better under a roof than in the open air, he is conducted to a hall, which he immediately stocks with all sorts of dainties. Pleased with his new quarters, Ahti now leads the life of an Oriental voluptuary, making all the women of the place his mistresses, with the exception of one poor girl, who is deeply mortified by his neglect. In compliance with the earnest solicitations of this slighted beauty, he proceeds by night to her residence, and as he passes through a number of villages, perceives that all the men are armed for his destruction, his mode of life having proved less agreeable to the male than to the female part of the population. It is clear that he must at once quit his pleasant abode; and as his boat is reduced to ashes, he manufactures a new one out of a very